

MARIA HESS

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SUMMARY

Strategic BD and partnerships leader with 20+ years building partner ecosystems from the ground up. Track record of mapping complex, multi-stakeholder opportunities, designing novel commercial models, and landing deals that open durable new revenue channels. Proven at working across product, legal, finance, and operations to bring partnerships from concept to launch. Deep experience influencing executive-level stakeholders across multi-sided ecosystems. Builder mindset: effective at the 0→1, most experienced at translating ambiguous market opportunities into clear strategy, prioritized roadmaps, and measurable revenue impact.

EXPERIENCE

Amazon Web Services (AWS)

Head of VC Partnerships, Global VC & Startups BD

Oct 2025 – Present

- Own AWS's strategic relationships with top-tier VC firms globally; define joint GTM strategy across each firm's portfolio and turn partner relationships into measurable pipeline and revenue.
- Map and manage a multi-sided ecosystem of investors, platform partners, and AI-native founders; translate ecosystem dynamics into actionable joint business plans and commercial frameworks that activate partners at scale.
- Build and maintain executive-level relationships (Director/VP/GP/MD-level) across the partner ecosystem, from seed-stage founders through growth-stage portfolio companies.
- Operate as player/coach: personally close strategic partnerships while aligning cross-functional execution across Sales, Solutions Architects, Product, and Marketing.

Head of Venture Platform, Startups & VC Business Development

Sep 2023 – Oct 2025

- Built and led the Platform team for AWS Startups & VC BD; 9 direct reports owning GTM strategy, enablement programs, and operating cadence across the global venture-backed founder portfolio.
- Designed and scaled a portfolio of 0→1 programs—four executive fellowships segmented by C-suite role—generating \$95.1M in ARR opportunities and 5,000+ engagements with founders and senior leaders.
- Built the strategy-to-execution handoff model: defined commercial logic and partner programs, then structured clean handoffs to scale partners—owning the BD/strategy layer while Operations owned activation and ongoing performance.
- Drove cross-functional alignment across Sales, BD, Product, Marketing, and Legal to convert ad-hoc partner engagements into repeatable, segmented go-to-market motions.

Head of Startup Programs, Startups & VC Business Development

Oct 2022 – Sep 2023

- Built the global startup programs portfolio for AWS Startups & Investor BD—designed the commercial and engagement architecture translating AWS's platform into structured value for the venture-backed founder community.
- Designed executive enablement programs for CEOs, CTOs, CROs, and CFOs; scaled to thousands of engagements across hundreds of startups spanning regulated and high-growth sectors.
- Established the operating foundation that became the AWS Startups & VC Platform team; promoted to Head of Platform after one year.

Madrona Venture Labs (of Madrona Venture Group)

Partner

May 2019 – Oct 2022

- Served as Partner and acting CEO across eight 0→1 AI-native, B2B startups in 3.5 years—leading market discovery, commercial model design, product prototyping, partner strategy, and early GTM for each.
- Built repeatable commercial playbooks for product-market fit and go-to-market applied across the portfolio; partnered with Madrona Venture Group GPs on investment decisions and founding-team composition.
- Portfolio included companies in regulated and compliance-intensive industries: Outbound AI (AI agents for healthcare workflows; \$23M seed), Strike Graph (AI-native compliance; \$24M in funding; #1 on G2), and Vouched (AI-native identity & KYC/KYA verification; \$17M Series A).
- Also incubated: Pendulum (narrative risk intelligence; \$24M seed), Magnify (agentic AI for customer growth; \$5B revenue under management), and Muir AI (AI-native supply chain intelligence; \$3.8M seed, S&P Global partnership).

PicMonkey (acquired by Shutterstock for \$110M)

Chief Revenue Officer

Apr 2012 – Oct 2017

- Led the revenue organization through five years of growth to \$17M ARR and a \$110M acquisition, owning subscription growth, partnerships, commercial model design, and analytics.
- Designed the conversion and retention motion driving subscription revenue: pricing, packaging, and lifecycle marketing.
- Structured and negotiated strategic partnerships delivering the company's primary revenue line; owned all commercial terms, partner economics, and performance through the acquisition.

EARLIER EXPERIENCE

Likewise (acquired by Watchlist, Inc.) – VP of Marketing, Gates Ventures-backed consumer app; drove launch to 1M+ installs and 2M user-generated recommendations in year one (2017–2018)

Google, Inc. – Product Marketing Manager, Google+ / Google Photos integration (2010–2011)

Picnik (acquired by Google) – Director, Monetization (2009–2010)

Expedia, Inc. – Director, Strategy & Product Development; Senior Manager; Account Executive (2003–2008)

Amazon.com – Senior Product Manager, Hardlines & Software (1999–2003)

EDUCATION

University of Washington, Foster School of Business – MBA

American University – MS, Health Management

Denison University – BA